



Validating the Opportunity

Name:

Startup Name:

Date:

Section:

Please read instructions carefully and follow all prompts below. After saving the file containing your responses, please submit the form. Instructions for how to submit assignments, including file naming conventions, are detailed on your syllabus.

Action: First, list eight potential interviewees that are good matches for your persona (table 3.1). Rate these people on a scale of 1 to 5, based on how well they fit your hypothesized persona and how urgent you believe solving the problem or job to be done will be for them. Once you are satisfied with your persona list, select two people who qualify as experts and who you believe might help you gain access to the people you listed, or who might help you improve the quality of the persona list. If you can't find two or three people who might fit your persona hypothesis, you might want to go back to the drawing board and come up with a product or service that is compelling to more people. It is important not to be afraid of asking people you think might be customers for introductions to people *they* think might be potential customers, and so on.

Table 3.1 Interviewee List

Customer Name	Job Title, Relevant Role, Employer	Email, Phone	Rate 1 (very low) to 5 (very high)	
			Fit with Persona	Urgency of Job to Be Done
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				
7				
8				
9				
10				
Expert Name	Job Title, Relevant Role, Employer	Email, Phone	Qualifications as Expert	
1				
2				

Table 3.2 Event List

Event Name	Planned Date(s)	Why is this event appropriate for job or persona discovery?
1		
2		
3		
4		
5		
6		
7		
8		
9		
10		

Action: Now it is your turn to try your hand at building your own opportunity validation interview protocol, using the protocol blank in table 3.4. Consider the first or second most promising person on your contact list. What kinds of questions do you need to ask them? How much time can they afford to give you? Make sure you leave at least three to five minutes for each response, and have some follow-up questions ready in case the person you are speaking with ends up giving you short answers. *Remember to get a sense of what the job to be done is and how important it is to this person, and to start with open-ended questions that elicit rich stories.*

Table 3.4 Interview Protocol (Blank)

1
2
3
4
5
6
7
8
9
10

Action: To help you organize and understand the results of your interviews, fill out the log in table 3.5 after each interview. It is also helpful to listen to a recording of the interview (obtained with the interviewee's permission) while you fill out the form. Begin by listing the name of the interviewee, how long the interview took, and whether you received permission to contact them again. Follow with lessons learned from the interview, an insightful quote, and any referrals received for additional interviews with other people who either are experts or fit the persona profile.

This form should not be the only repository of data you maintain. It is meant to be shorthand and is designed as a way for you to communicate your findings with advisers

or members of your founding team. Although I only include four slots in the book, you should not restrict yourself to conducting only four interviews. In fact, you should keep going until you feel confident that all the questions posed in your protocol have been answered in the same way by several subjects. Some teams generate these worksheets and start categorizing their interviewees into persona categories, sometimes finding new and interesting potential markets in the process.

Table 3.5 Interview Log

	Interviewee Name / Date, Time Spent / Reengage?	Lessons Learned	Referral(s)
1	Name:		
	Date:		
	Time Spent:		
	Permission to Reengage (Yes/No)		
2			
3			
4			

Additional interviews with individuals who fit your persona profile should be conducted throughout your new venture's development process. As one might expect, investors will not be impressed by founders who claim to have validated that an opportunity exists after 4 interviews.